PROCESS RESEARCH

The Deposit Came In. Why Is the Job Still Waiting?

The process your team draws in a meeting can be very different from the one a customer goes through.



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A customer asks your construction firm whether work can start on the 12th. Sales has the signed proposal. The project manager says scheduling is waiting for the deposit. Finance received the deposit on Tuesday and applied it to the customer's account. Nobody attached it to the job. In the procedure, payment confirmation and scheduling sit in boxes next to each other. In the customer's week, the payment lands on Tuesday and the start date is still open on Thursday.

The director who wants to fix scheduling has two options on the table. Add a coordinator, or buy a tool that shows every job on one calendar. The signed proposal and the deposit receipt give her somewhere better to start.

Map a real business process by following one job from the event that started it to the point the customer or next team could act. Record what people knew, what they did, when the work waited, and where it came back. Compare the map with other jobs before committing to a change.

How do you find the delay that matters?

Use dated records to distinguish work from waiting. Ask what had to be true for the next person to act, who could make that true, and when they had the information. A delay visible in scheduling may begin in the way another department releases a job.

Think of picking up an online order at Target. In its description of Drive Up, Target tells the customer to wait until the order is ready, then use the app to say they're on the way. The store can prepare the order before the car reaches the pickup spot. Draw the process from the customer's side and you can see two different intervals. The store needs time to get the order ready. The customer also needs to know when they can leave home. If you measure only the time spent in the parking spot, the first wait is invisible. Target's description of Drive Up

Look at your own handoff with that question. Can the project manager prepare a crew plan while finance confirms the deposit? Can sales request site access when the proposal is signed? Some steps can move earlier. Others protect the business from committing labor or placing orders before the job is ready. Identify which is which.

What should a process map record?

Capture the event, time, evidence, decision owner, and what happened next. Mark when a record arrived and when somebody could use it. Keep the customer's view alongside the internal timeline so a completed step can be checked against the result it was meant to produce.

Day	Internal record	What the customer could do
Monday	Signed proposal received. Sales sends the deposit instructions.	Send payment and make a provisional plan.
Tuesday	Finance sees the deposit under the account. No job ID appears on the payment.	Ask when work will start.
Thursday	Project manager follows up. Finance matches the payment to the job.	Still waiting on a date.
Friday	Scheduling sees clearance and can reserve a crew.	Confirm the start and arrange access.

Use this as a **Work Map**. In a real case, open the proposal, payment record and scheduling entry. Ask where the customer first saw a reliable start date. The U.K. Government Digital Service's mapping guidance recommends looking at the whole problem from the user's side alongside the organizations and steps involved. That prevents the business from measuring success at a handoff the customer experiences as another wait. GOV.UK whole-problem mapping guidance

How do you test what the map suggests?

Make one reversible change that would affect the suspected wait. If deposits often arrive without a job identifier, include the job reference in payment instructions and give finance a defined way to resolve unmatched payments. Track whether scheduling gets confirmation earlier and whether any jobs are cleared in error.

Compare a few ordinary jobs and a job with a genuine exception. If deposits already match correctly and scheduling still waits, look at when a crew is available or who can authorize a start. Keep the procedure available as a reference for which checks are intended to protect the company. Keep the observed map as evidence of what happened.

How do you distinguish a one-off delay from the way the business works?

Compare a job that cleared quickly with a similar one that stalled. In a quick job, the customer may have put the quote number in the payment because a rep asked for it. In the slow job, the same instruction may have been missing. That comparison gives the team a sharper experiment than telling finance to work faster.

Also inspect a deliberate exception. Suppose the owner pays a deposit covering two sites. The job reference can help finance identify the account, but someone still has to allocate the payment before both jobs are released. A useful map shows the standard path and where the exception branches. The business can now decide whether to change the payment instructions, define authority to allocate payments, or make both easier to see on the schedule.

Three things to take into the mapping meeting.

- Bring one real job and open its dated records.
- Ask what the customer was waiting for at each handoff.
- Try a change that would shorten the wait if your explanation is right.

The next time a customer asks about the 12th, the person answering should be able to see whether payment is matched, the crew can be scheduled, and who can make the remaining decision.

Frequently asked questions

Does a process map need special software?

A short timeline or table is enough to investigate one job. Add a visual map if it helps teams understand parallel steps, decisions, or loops.

Can one job establish the cause of a recurring problem?

It can show where to look. Compare other jobs, including ones that went smoothly, to see which conditions repeat.

Should the company skip a control that causes a wait?

First find out what risk the control protects against. Check whether it can happen earlier, receive better information, or be applied only where it is needed.

The construction job is illustrative. Target's pickup sequence comes from its public description of Drive Up.